

Michael Chaves

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Creative Director & Creative Technologist | Product Design & Interactive Experiences

Creative director, creative technologist, and product designer with an MDes in Experience Design. Led branding, visual storytelling, and digital experiences across all Knitting Factory Entertainment venues and subsidiaries. Brings that creative foundation to AI products, interactive media, and immersive experiences, owning concepts through visual direction, high-fidelity prototypes, and launch. Uses code, real-time 3D, and AI-assisted workflows to turn ideas into working experiences.

SKILLS

Creative Direction & Visual Storytelling: Brand identity, graphic design, digital campaigns, live-event visuals, creative team leadership, Figma, Adobe Creative Suite, motion

Product & Experience Design: Visual and interaction design, design systems and tokens, UI architecture and components, high-fidelity prototyping, user research, usability testing, design QA, workflow design, stakeholder alignment, engineering collaboration

Interactive & Immersive Experiences: Unity3D, C#, WebGL, real-time 3D, game UX, spatial interfaces, XR/AR/VR, immersive simulation, accessibility-focused prototyping

AI & Conversational UX: Voice and voice+screen UX, intent and response mapping, human-in-the-loop workflows, structured outputs, LLM evaluation and training data, retrieval, tool use, reliability testing

Creative Prototyping & Delivery: React, Next.js 15, TypeScript, JavaScript, Tailwind, shadcn/ui, AI-assisted development, Postgres, Drizzle ORM, Neon, Vercel, GitHub Actions, REST APIs, Cloudflare Workers, GCP, AWS

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

UGC Engineer

Astrocade | Los Altos, CA | Contract | Nov 2025 – Apr 2026

- Owned end-to-end AI-assisted UGC review and publishing workflows for a game creation platform, connecting automated evaluation, QA annotation, final-review UI, creator feedback loops, and daily publishing under a one-day turnaround target.
- Designed calibration interfaces, decision rubrics, and review artifacts that compared automated outputs with human judgment, reducing false rejections, surfacing repeat-rejection patterns, and improving reviewer consistency.
- Identified bottlenecks across automated and human workflows and translated production failures into tooling, design QA, documentation, and operational fixes that improved throughput and review consistency under production constraints.

AI Expert Contributor

Snorkel AI | Remote | Contract | Apr 2025 – Oct 2025

- Authored and validated original, high-difficulty graduate-level problems, reference answers, and evaluation criteria to test LLM reasoning; assessed AI-generated responses, identified reasoning flaws, and refined model outputs.
- Contributed to proprietary training datasets used for fine-tuning, benchmarking, and reinforcement learning, documenting failure modes in logic, computation, and mathematical reasoning.

Lead UX/UI Designer III

Starbucks | Seattle, WA | Contract | Mar 2022 – Dec 2022

- Designed high-fidelity VR and mobile internal tools for learning and operations modules, using research, interaction and visual design, prototyping, and usability testing to improve task completion and simulation fidelity.
- Partnered with engineering and ML stakeholders to prototype AI-enhanced simulations and high-fidelity interaction flows that translated complex workflows into usable training experiences.

Unity Developer

Ford Motor Company | Dearborn, MI | Contract | Oct 2021 – Mar 2022

- Developed a Unity3D time-study tool deployed globally across manufacturing environments, translating physical operations into interactive software and contributing to over \$1M in annual operational savings per plant.
- Built WebGL dashboards with custom shaders and interactive data visualization, reducing data-entry time by 40% and making complex manufacturing workflows easier to review.

Front-End Web Developer

POWER Engineers | Meridian, ID | Jun 2020 – Oct 2021

- Led design and frontend development of GeoVoice, a web and VR platform for spatial storytelling, increasing stakeholder engagement by 60%.
- Built responsive interfaces and high-fidelity prototypes for geospatial and data-rich tools across web, AR, and VR, translating complex infrastructure data for non-technical stakeholders.

Creative Director

Knitting Factory Entertainment | Boise, ID | Aug 2008 – Jan 2016

- Directed digital creative projects and managed teams across all Knitting Factory venues and subsidiaries, unifying brand identity, visual storytelling, and promotional standards across web, campaign, and event experiences.
- Redesigned the ticketing platform and supporting digital experiences, increasing conversion rates by 25%; coordinated campaigns, event visuals, and interactive assets supporting live productions.

SELECTED PROJECTS

Wizzo | AI Mentor Platform, Wizzo Labs, Inc.

Founder & Creative Director | Aug 2025 – Present

- Led creative direction, product design, and launch of Wizzo, an AI mentor platform, owning concepts, visual systems, responsive UI, component architecture, and AI-assisted prototyping and implementation.
- Designed and shipped conversational and multimodal Today and Journey experiences spanning chat, tool guidance, personalization, files, web search, structured outputs, user controls, feedback, motion, and release surfaces; owned evaluation, design QA, and production reliability.

Playfold | AI-Powered Interactive Storytelling, Wizzo Labs, Inc.

Founder & Creative Director | Feb 2026 – Present

- Designed and shipped Playfold, turning social posts into characters, conflict, settings, visual plans, and playable mechanics across nine gameplay archetypes through an AI-native interpretation and game-generation pipeline.
- Directed visual and interaction design, product demos, social and video assets, and launch copy to improve legibility and playability; defined interpreter, director, critic, compiler, runtime, and human-calibration workflows for consistent results.

SpeakEasy | Voice-First Multimodal Mixed Reality Accessibility System

Master of Design Thesis | 2023 – 2025

- Designed and built a working Unity/Meta Quest voice-first MR accessibility prototype for users with low muscle tone, combining participatory research, AI-assisted intent recognition, and immersive interaction design.
- Trained a custom voice-intent AI model and mapped spoken commands to intents and interaction behaviors for hands-free navigation, object control, and mixed reality interaction logic.

EDUCATION

Master of Design, Experience Design

San José State University | May 2025

Bachelor of Science, Games, Interactive Media & Mobile Technology

Boise State University | May 2020

LEADERSHIP & RECOGNITION

- Snap Inc. Spectacles Accelerator, 2025: Built voice-first AR concepts focused on accessibility and spatial interaction.
- California Community Colleges Futures Summit, 2025, Santa Clara: Panelist on synthetic AI companions, personalized learning, teacher augmentation, student innovation, and responsible adoption.
- GatherVerse XREvolve, 2025: Presented “AR & AI: The Intersection of the Future.”
- XReality Podcast, Nov 2025: Discussed AI-assisted accessibility and voice-first XR experiences.
- XR Access Symposium, 2024, Cornell Tech, NYC: Presented voice-driven mixed reality work for inclusive interaction.
- Additional leadership: Adobe Student Ambassador (creative AI workshops, 2024); Perplexity AI Campus Strategist (academic GenAI adoption, 2024); LePal AI UX Fellow (digital health redesign, 2024); host, Adobe Experiential Horizons demo showcase (2023).